



THE LINUX FOUNDATION
OPEN SOURCE SUMMIT

NORTH AMERICA

The Accidental Maintainer: Sideways Stories into Open Source Leadership

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Hi there 🖐️



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- Kubernetes SIG Docs co-chair
- TODO Group Steering Committee



Why we're here today

Open source software is nearly universal in commercial applications, with 97% of all applications containing open source

[Source: The 2025 OSSRA Report by Blackduck](#)



But we also work for corporations, so...



Why we're *also* here today

We estimate the supply-side value of widely-used OSS is \$4.15 billion, but that the demand-side value is much larger at \$8.8 trillion. We find that firms would need to spend 3.5 times more on software than they currently do if OSS did not exist

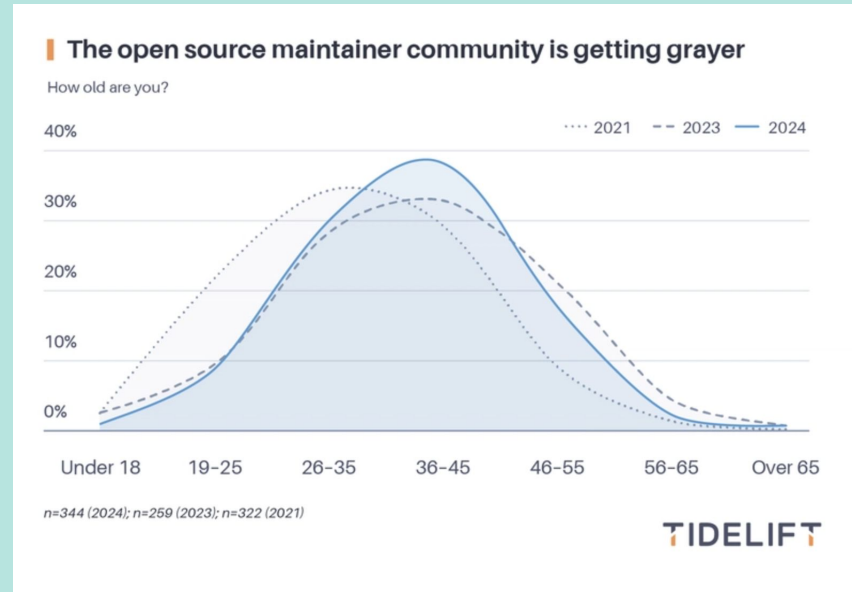
[Source: The Value of Open Source Software, Harvard Business School](#)



Who maintains open source?



Who maintains open source?



[Source: The 2024 Tidelfit State of the open source maintainer report](#)



Who maintains open source?

45% - 10 years+
24% - 6-10 years
23% - 2-5 years

[Source: The 2024 Tidelflife State of the open source maintainer report](#)



... the current maintainer population is aging, and new, younger maintainers aren't coming in to fill the gaps

Source: The 2024 Tidelift State of Open Source Maintainer Report



The graying open source community needs fresh blood

Deep experience of the older tech crowd is nothing short of vital, yet projects need new devs to move forward

[Source: https://www.theregister.com/2024/07/15/opinion_open_source_attract_devs/](https://www.theregister.com/2024/07/15/opinion_open_source_attract_devs/)



Agenda

- What does a maintainer do?
- Our “accidental” paths to leadership
- Common patterns
- Contributor ladders and their importance
- Making leadership intentional
 - As a maintainer
 - As a contributor





What does a maintainer do?

- Reviews PRs, issues, and moderates community meetings
- Coordinates with other maintainers and leaders
- Creates and enforces processes and rules for the community
- ... and much more!

But most importantly:

- Maintenance denotes ownership: owners make decisions



How did we (accidentally) become maintainers?



Natali's story

- Engineering manager
- Her expertise called out as needed by friends in Kubernetes
- First contribution = auth bug triage
- Auth / Docs / ContribEx / Release
- Localization subproject creator for Kubernetes docs
- Nominated for leadership group training
- Maintainer



Divya's story

- Kubernetes user
- Serial lurker in community meetings
- First contribution = docs edit
- Release team
 - Docs shadow
 - Comms shadow
 - Comms lead
 - Release lead shadow
- Leader-in-training
- Maintainer



Common patterns



Asking questions vs. answering questions

- New users and potential contributors ask for guidance
 - Who are the folks helping newbies by answering questions?
- Repeatedly asking the same questions is perceived as newbie behavior
 - Folks might refer to prior answers or existing resources: they've likely answered the same questions many times
- Maintainers ask questions, too! Look at the type of question to understand the nuance between new and seasoned contributors



Visibility and its implications

- Being visible in a project *can* denote some kind of seniority or authority, whether intended or not
 - It can also signal more importance for specific types of contributions over others
 - e.g. code over non-code, mentoring, or other forms of community work
- Projects with visible contributors attract newer contributors more easily
 - BUT this could lead to gamification of the process = less sustainable project

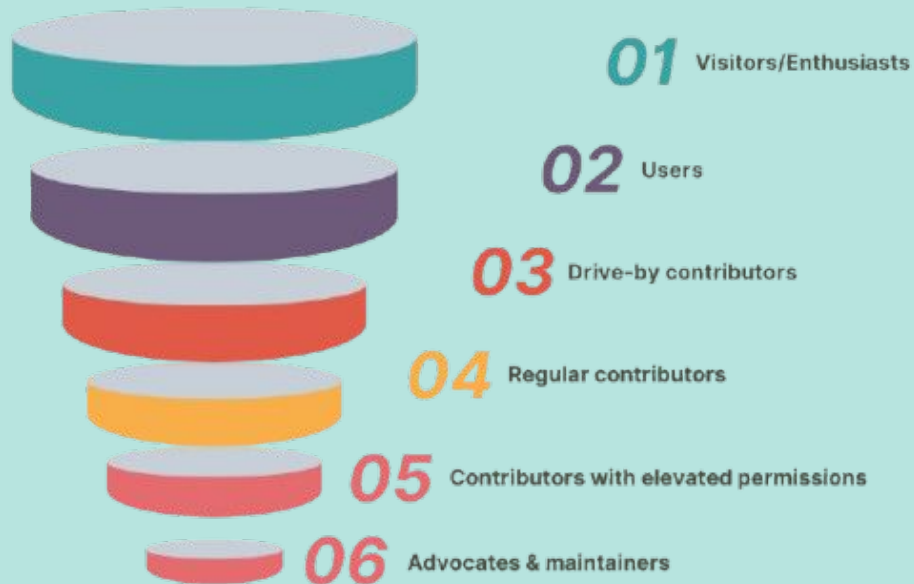


Why visibility isn't *always* good

- Pointing out problems vs. supplying a fix
 - Complaining about functionality vs. filing bugs and suggesting solutions
 - Combative comments instead of engaging in constructive feedback
- Failing to take accountability for your visible “role”
 - Perception vs. reality: are you signing up for something more?
- Knowing when to step back and defer to others
 - Artificial involvement leaves a bad smell



Contributor ladders and their importance



Contributor ladders and their importance

- Having a visible path to leadership matters
- Fostering a culture of trust in community building efforts
- Helps engage sustained contributors over time
- The unspoken rule: maintainers also maintain the contributor ladder!
- Aids in distributing the load among maintainers
 - Reduces load on single maintainer (queue : [obligatory xkcd comic](#))



Example – the CNCF contributor ladder

- Contributors
- Approvers
- Maintainers
- Bonus:
 - Involuntary removal
 - Stepping down/Emeritus process
 - Stepping back into a role

Source: <https://glossary.cncf.io/contributor-ladder/>



Example – the ASF contributor ladder

- User
- Contributor
- Committer
- PMC Member
- Foundation Member
- Officers of the Foundation
- Board of Directors

Source: <https://community.apache.org/contributor-ladder.html>



Making leadership intentional

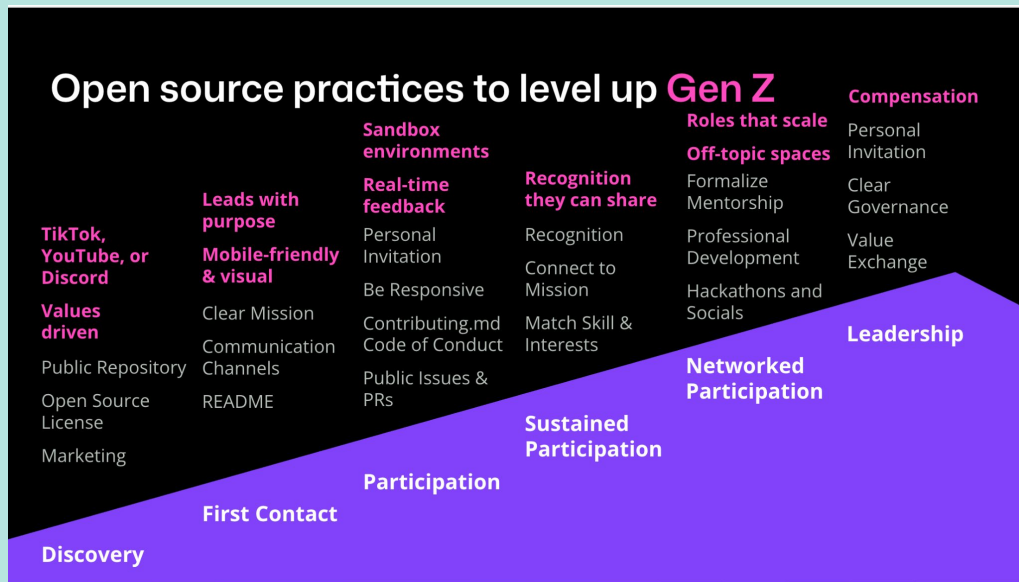


Making leadership intentional – maintainer

- Design yourself out of your job
 - Create roles on the contributor ladder that make the path to leadership more visible
 - Recognize and incentivize impactful contributions
 - Assign elevated permissions, named roles, or titles
 - Tokens of appreciation – swag etc.
- Nurture future generations of contributors through mentorship
 - Both Natali & Divya were beneficiaries of a mentorship cohort for maintainers
 - Doesn't mean informal mentorship cannot play its part here, too!



Making leadership intentional – maintainer



Credit: Abigail Cabunoc Mayes, Who will maintain the future? Tackling the graying of open source software

Making leadership intentional – contributor

- Learn the community conventions and decision-making processes
- Identify **and** address real needs within the project
- Earn trust through consistent, reliable contributions and collaboration
- Always pay it forward!
 - Seek mentorship
 - Also, mentor newer folks as you grow
- The path to leadership is a marathon, not a sprint
 - Be patient!



Are YOU a leader in your project?

- Leadership patterns
 - Answering questions
 - Guiding newbies
 - Fixing issues identified by the community
- Visibility in the project: what are you known for?
 - Making decisions
 - High level of technical expertise
 - You have a reputation: is that a positive thing?



Interested in contributing?

- Join Kubernetes Slack <https://slack.k8s.io>
 - Join #sig-docs Slack channel and ask questions!
- Read our contributing guide
 - Contributing to Kubernetes Docs: <https://kubernetes.io/docs/contribute/docs/>
 - Be familiar with the PR process
- Join the SIG's mailing list to get calendar invites:
<https://groups.google.com/g/kubernetes-sig-docs/>
 - New Contributor Meet & Greet, first Tuesday of the month @ 10:30 UTC



Thank you!

